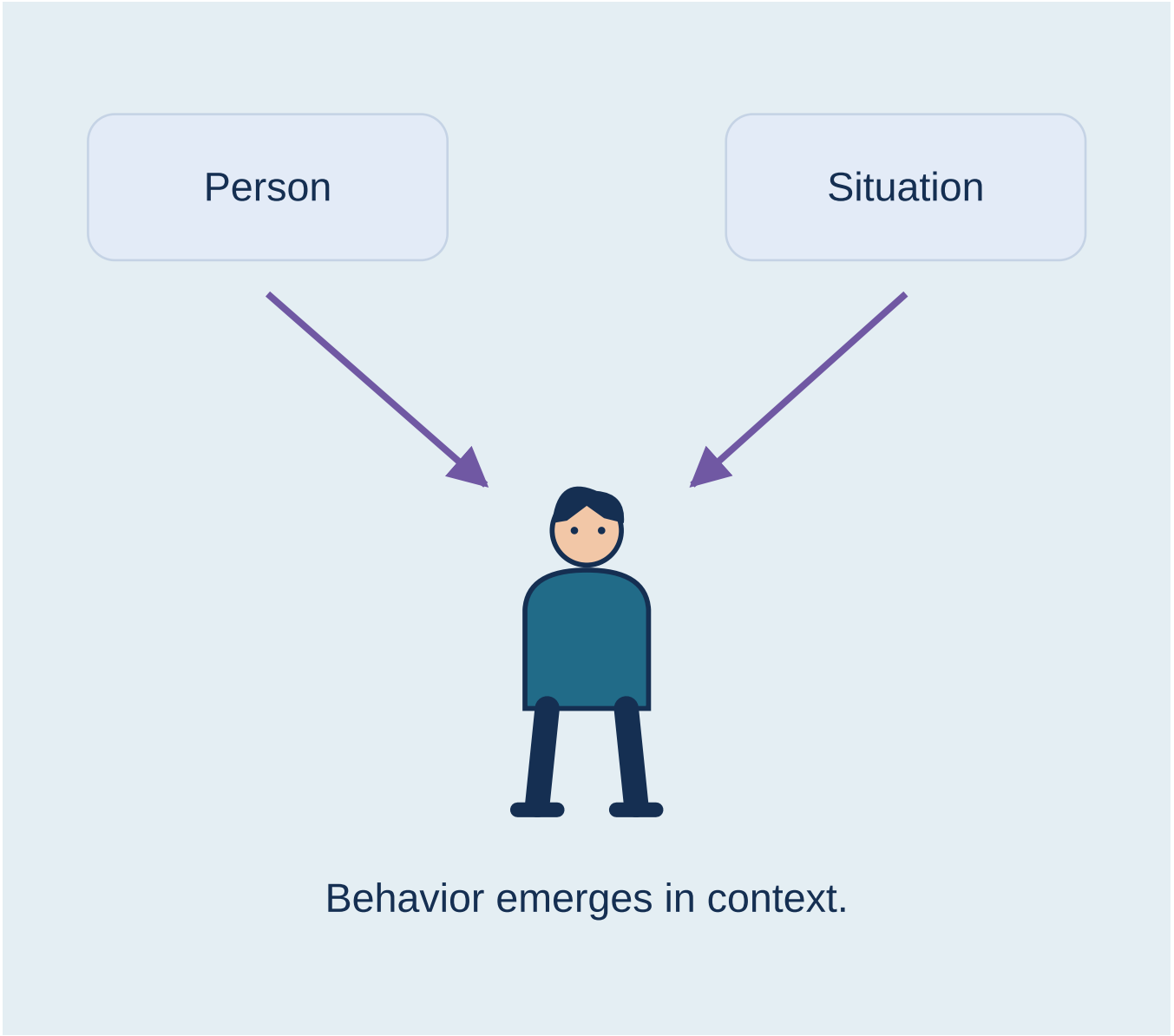
Common Ground
Visual companion

Explore every teaching concept through original diagrams and fictional café examples. Each caption explains the idea and its limits.

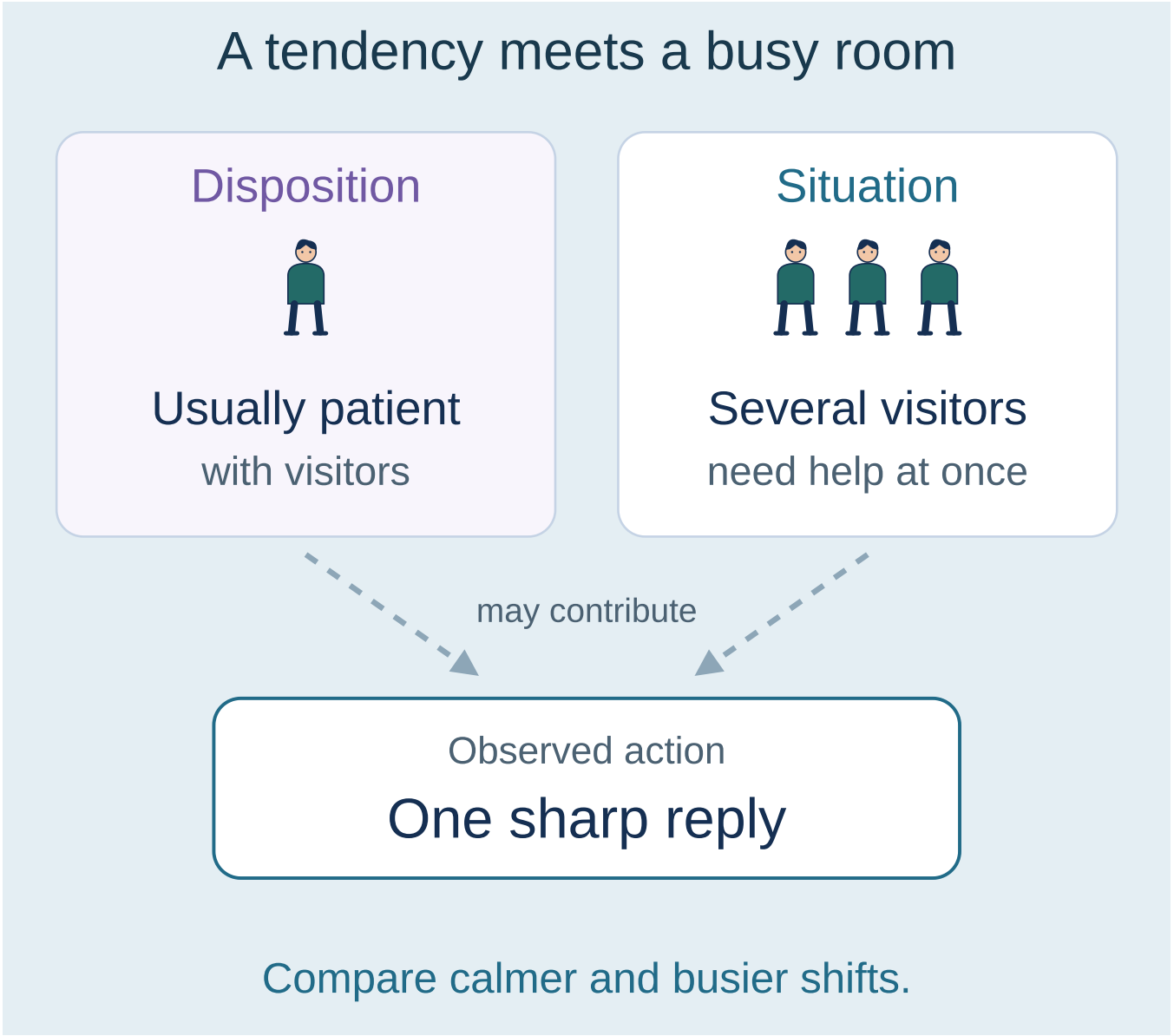
48 visual explanations across ten chapters. The chapter slides show the main figure, with additional views under “More visual explanations.” This companion brings every view together for reading and printing.

Person, disposition, and situation



A disposition is one personal quality; circumstances also contribute.

Disposition under changing demands



A hypothetical interaction of a disposition and a situation. Dashed paths indicate possible contributions.

Observation and attribution

Two different questions

Observation



Maya arrived after the start.

A recorded action

Attribution



“She doesn’t care.”

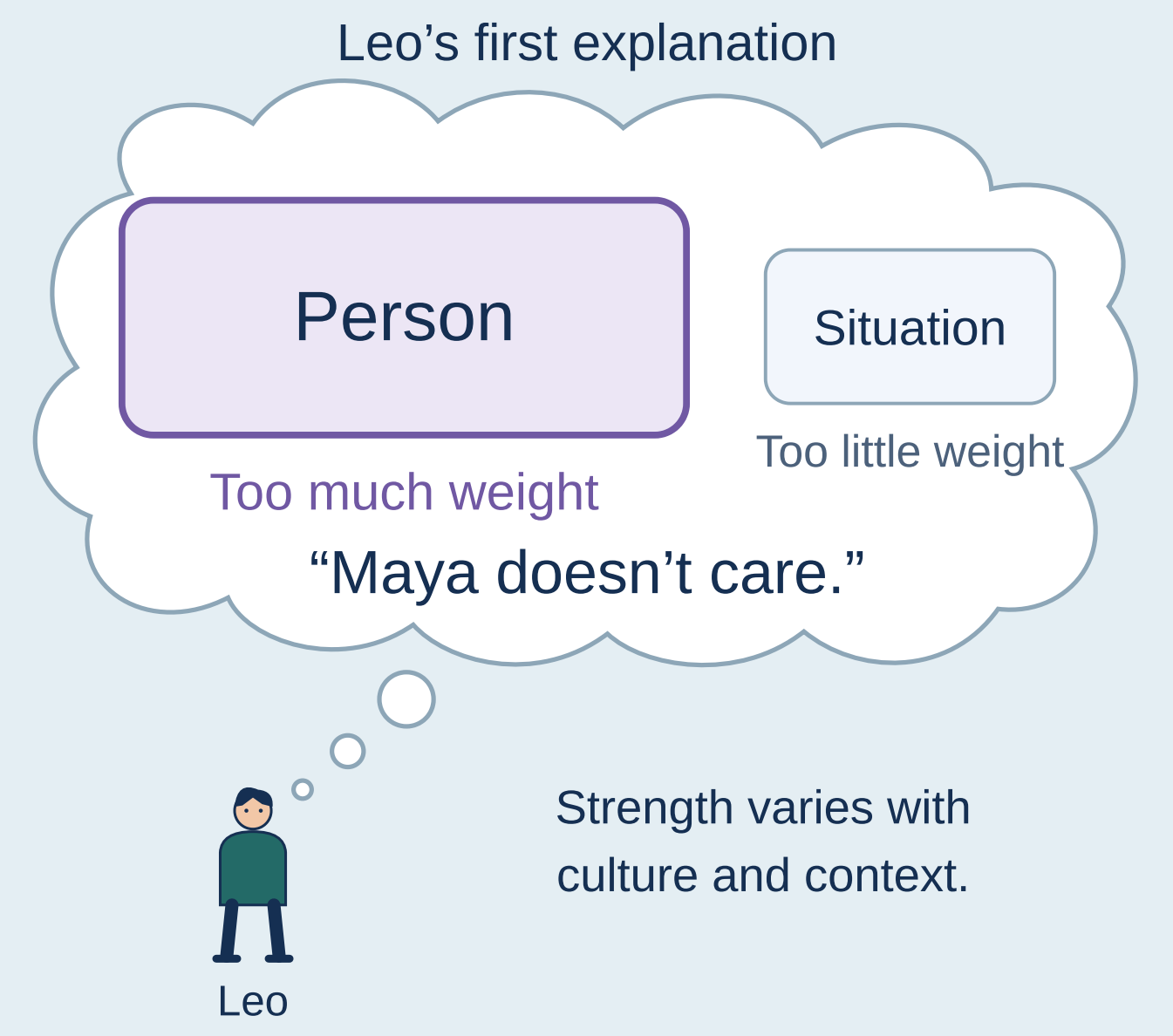
A proposed cause

One statement records an action.
The other proposes a cause.

What evidence could test Leo’s cause?

Leo’s observation and his attribution answer different questions.

Fundamental attribution error



Leo gives personal qualities more weight than the circumstances.

Attribution and actor–observer differences

One observer, two explanations

Leo explains himself



“The bus was delayed.”
Circumstances

Leo explains Maya



“She doesn’t care.”
A personal tendency
Could he be missing her circumstances?

A possible actor–observer difference.
The pattern depends on judgment and setting.

Hypothetical explanations by the same observer.

Test an explanation against evidence

Follow the evidence

Leo’s proposed cause

“She doesn’t care.”

1

Describe the action

Maya arrived after the start.

Keep the cause open.

2

Compare occasions

Is lateness usual across shifts?

Look for exceptions.

3

Check alternatives

Could a travel barrier explain it?

Ask Maya about the delay.

4

Revise your confidence

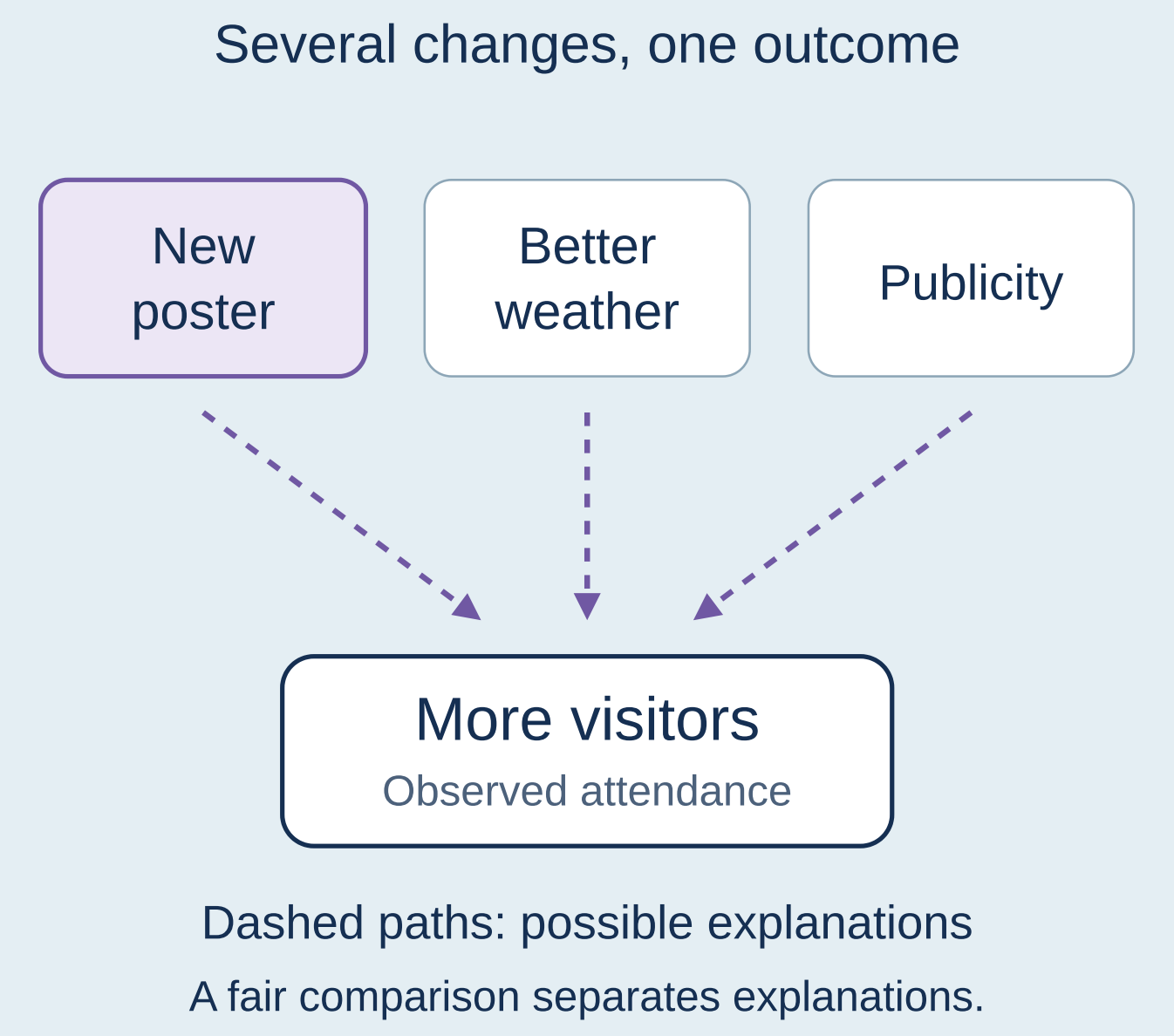
Weigh the evidence for each cause.

Allow your explanation to change.

Let evidence change your confidence.

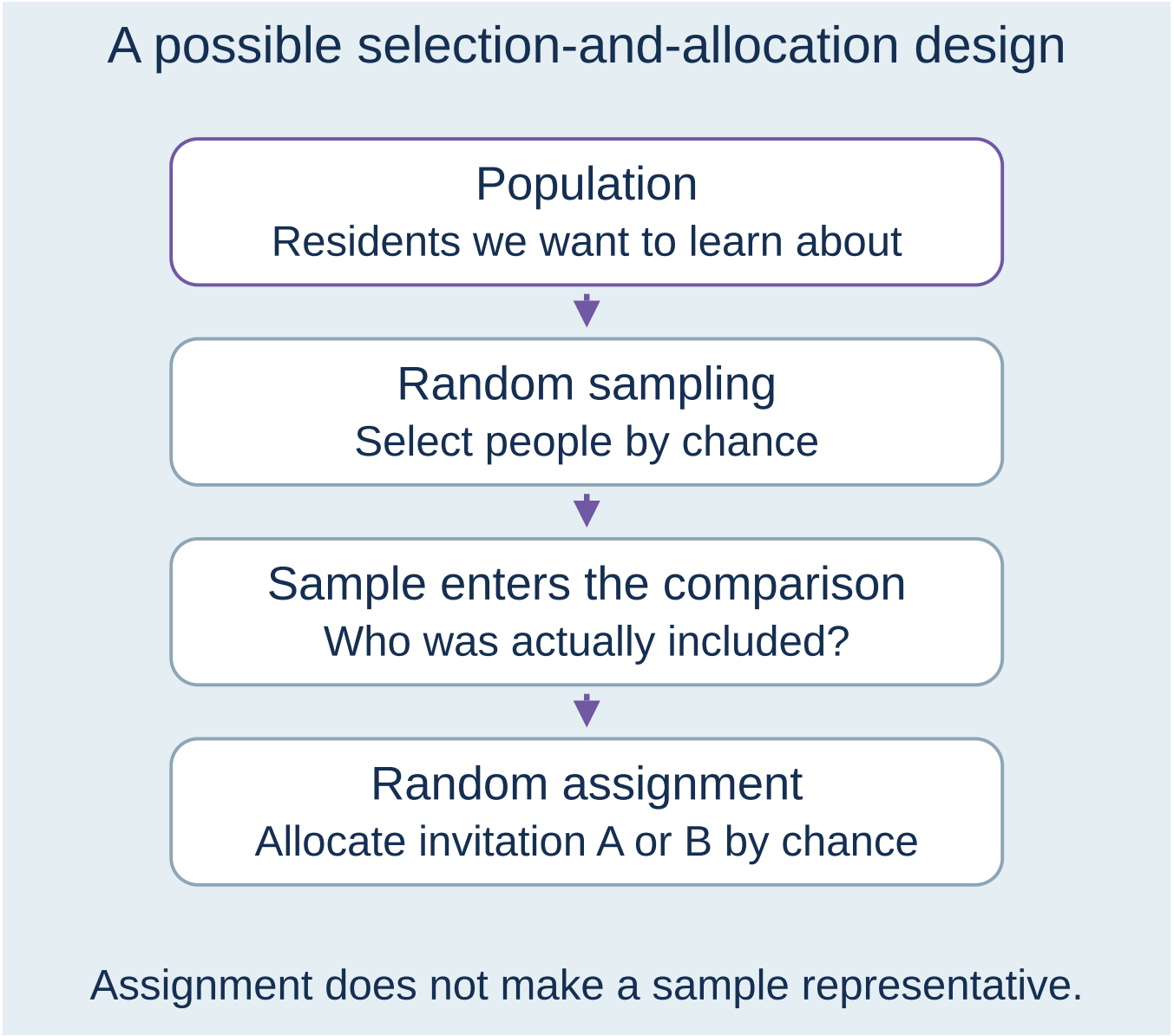
Describe, compare, check, and revise. Apply the same steps to your own interpretations.

Confounding



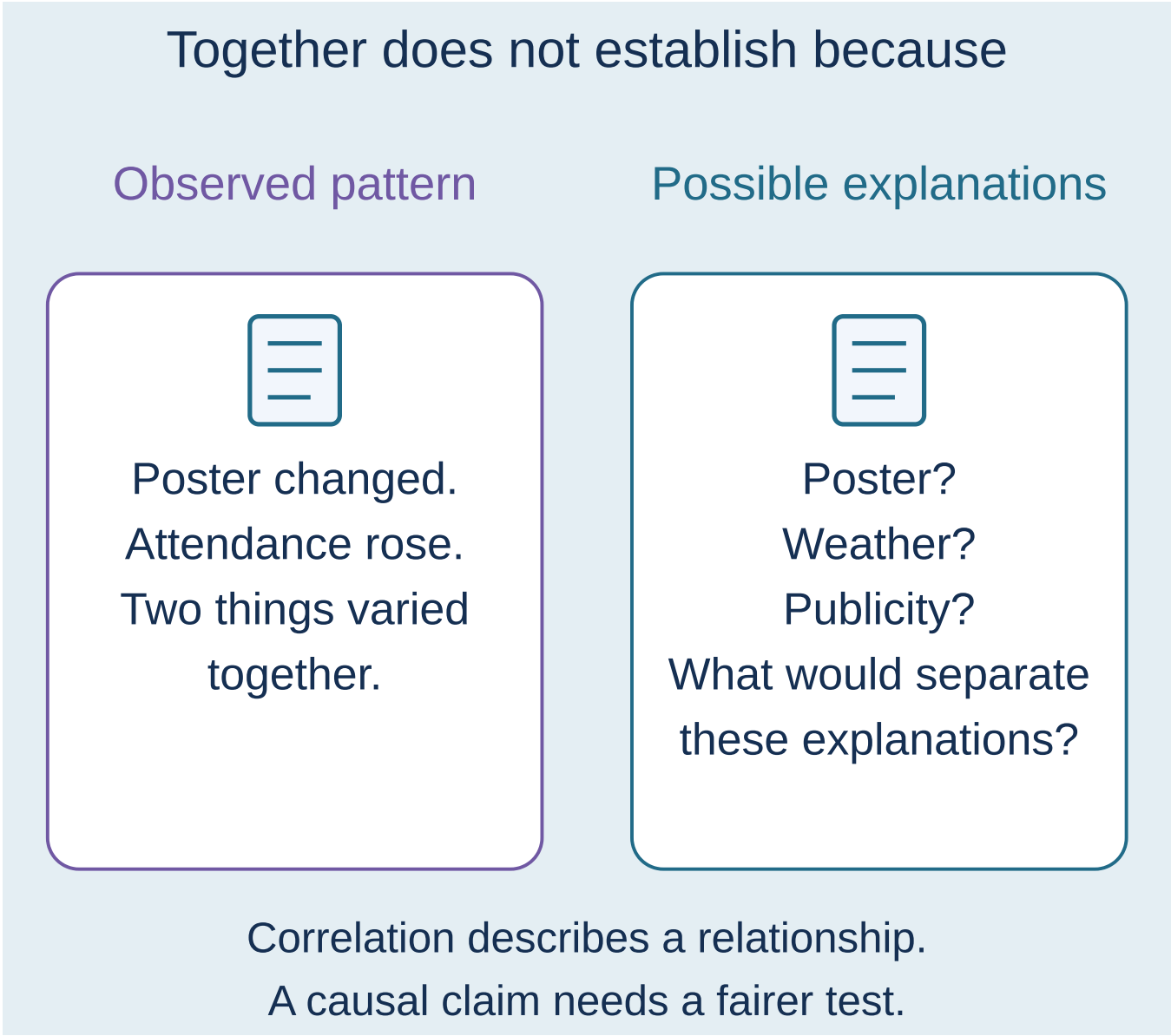
Several changes can fit the same before-and-after pattern.

Random sampling and random assignment



Choosing the sample and assigning conditions answer different questions.

Correlation and causation



A shared pattern leaves multiple causes possible.

Effect size and uncertainty

Invented attendance example

Invitation A



12 of 100 households attend

Invitation B



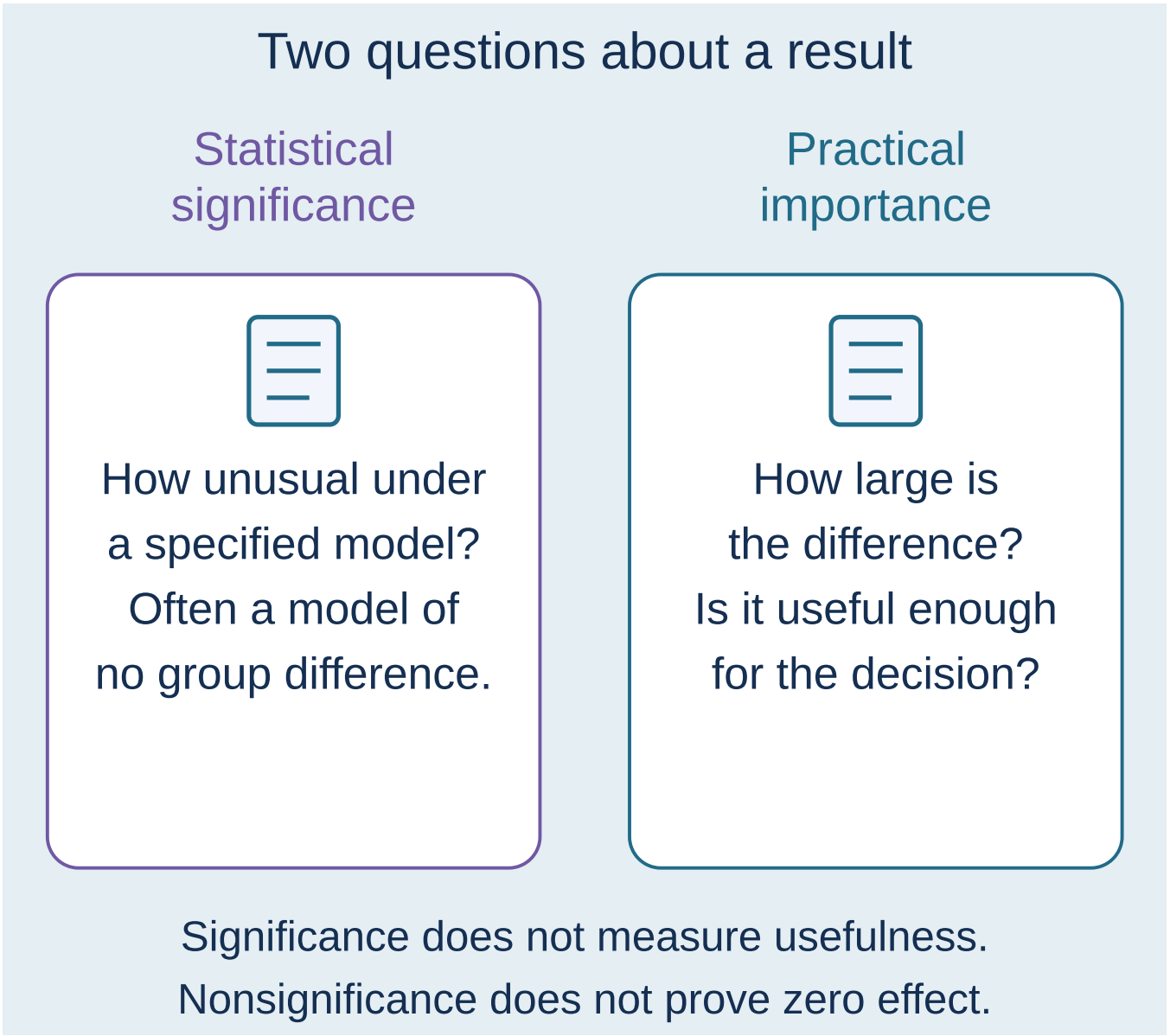
15 of 100 households attend

15% − 12% = 3 percentage points

A different sample could give a different estimate.

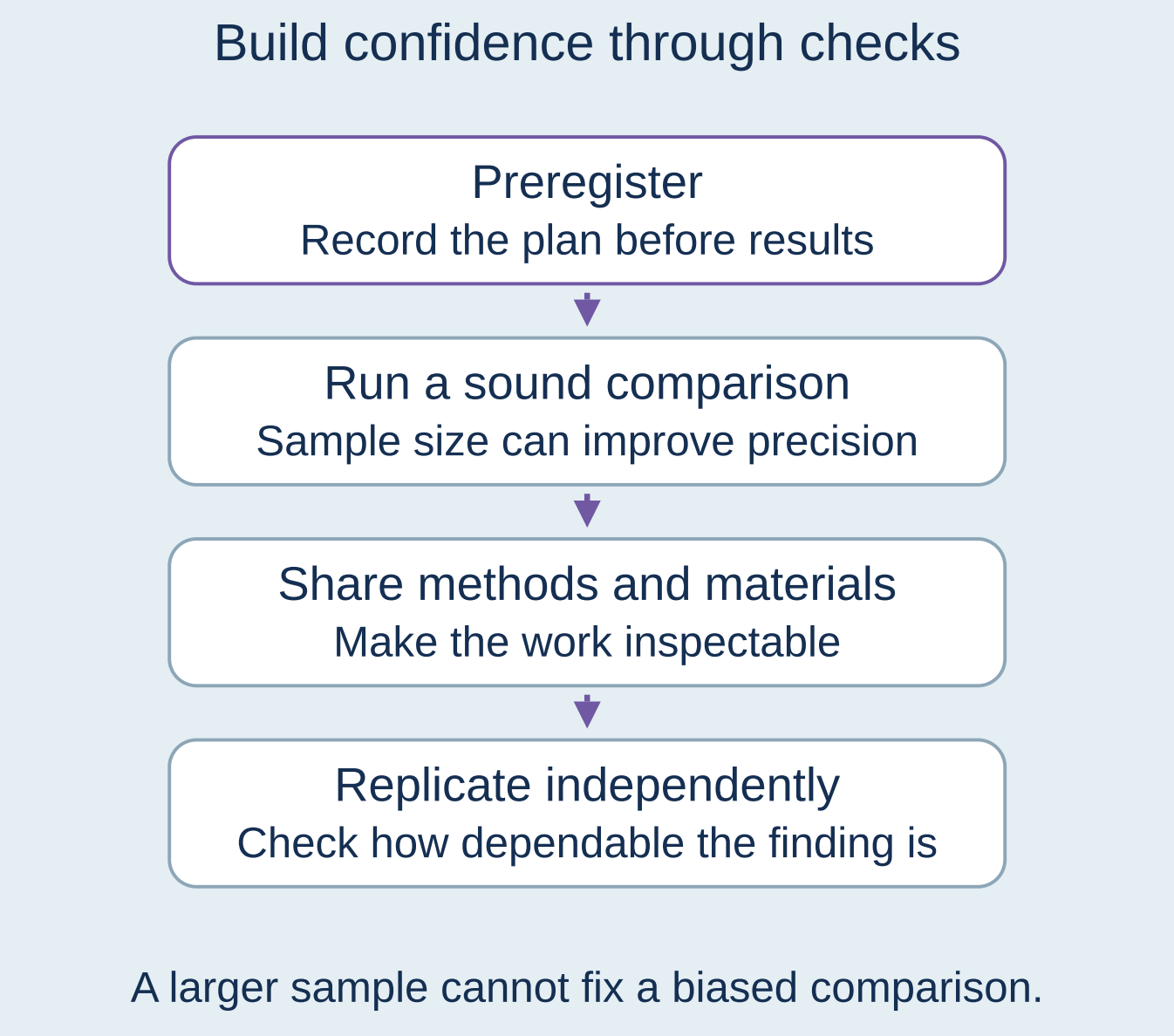
Invented counts illustrate the size of a difference.

Statistical significance and practical importance



Model-based evidence and practical value are different questions.

Preregistration, transparency, and replication



Plan, inspect, and independently repeat a sound comparison.

Availability heuristic, base rates, and denominators

A vivid case needs a denominator

“That toaster failed again!”

Invented record: all comparable repairs

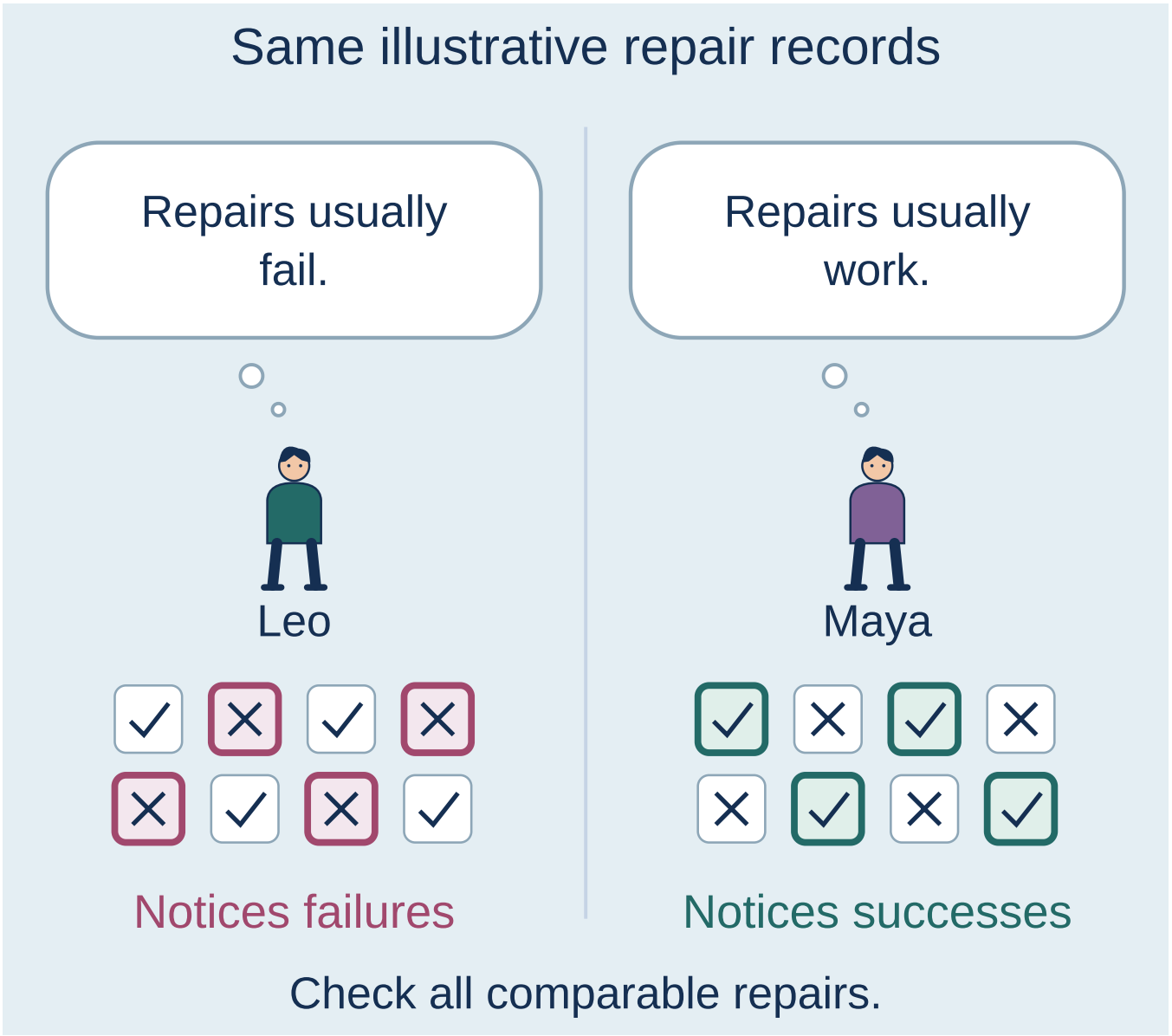


4 failures / 40 repairs = 10%

Availability is a shortcut, not a frequency count.

The invented whole record gives a vivid case its denominator.

Confirmation bias



Expectations can change which evidence gets attention.

Motivated reasoning



Maya’s desired outcome may shape how she judges the evidence.

Check a bias claim against evidence

Checking someone else’s estimate

Possible distortion



Vivid cases get too much attention. The record does not support the initial estimate.

Possible expertise

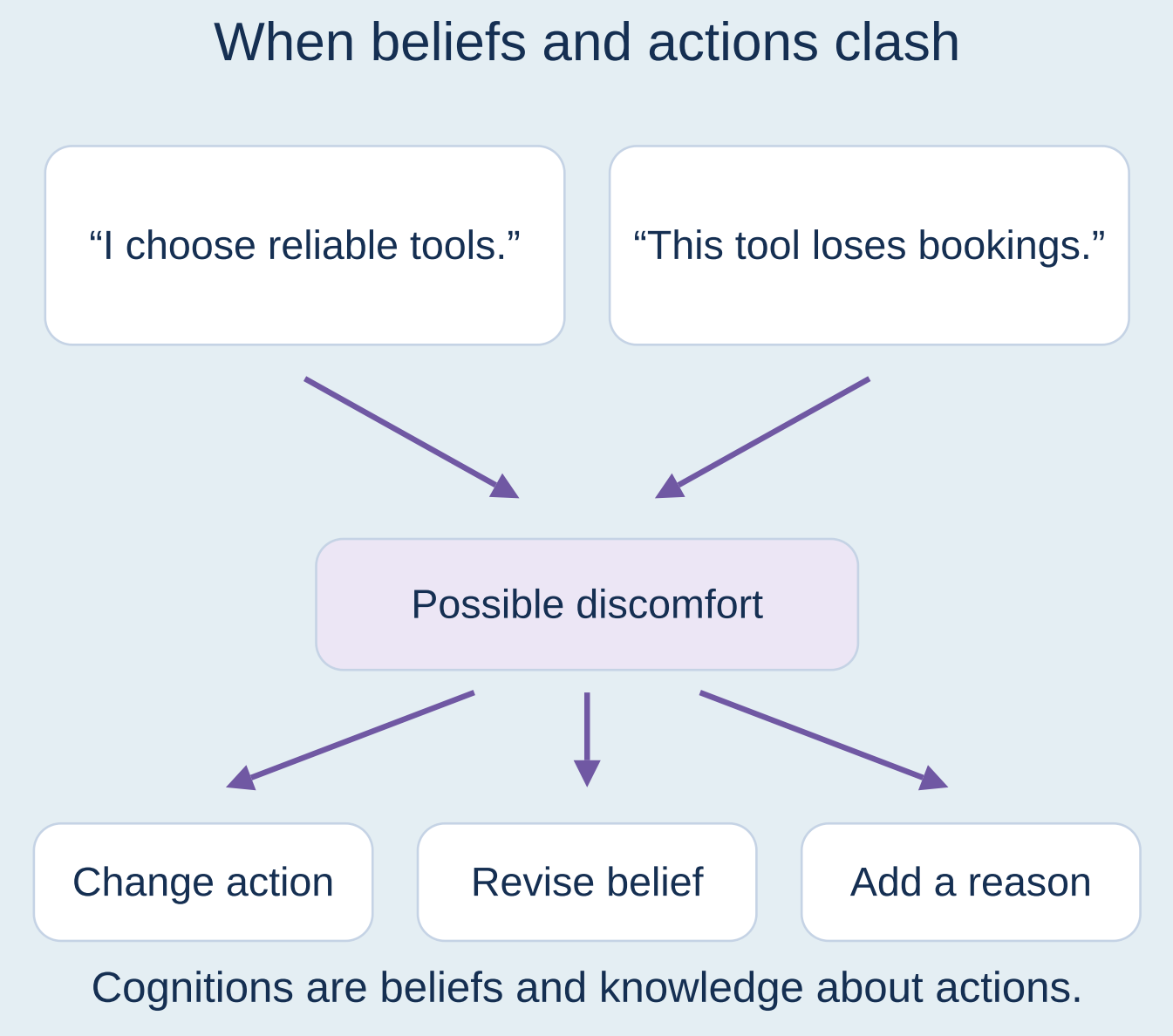


Remembered cases reflect experience. A representative record supports the estimate.

Compare their estimate with a relevant record. Ask which cases they considered.

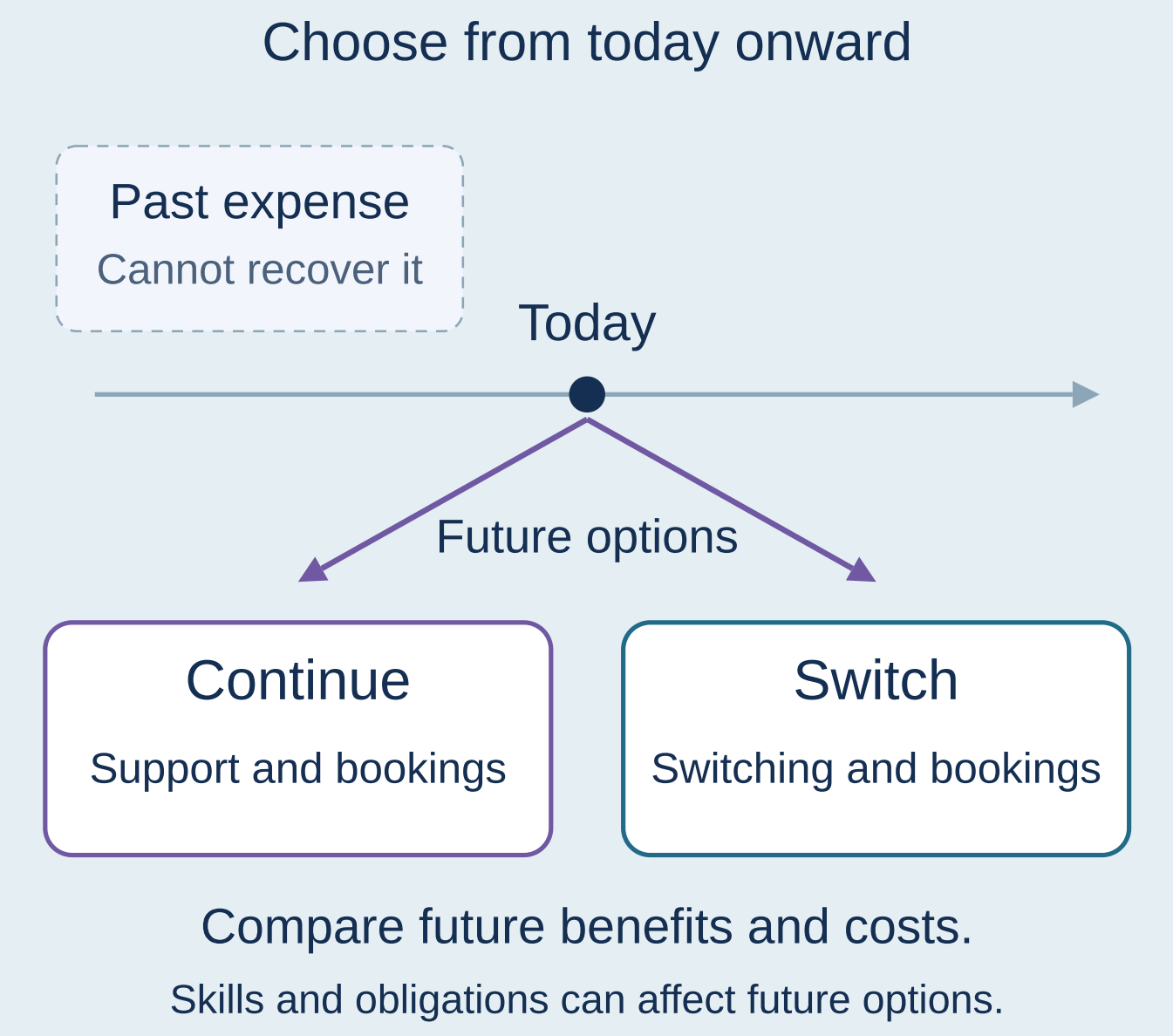
Compare another person’s estimate with the record behind it.

Cognitive dissonance and cognitions



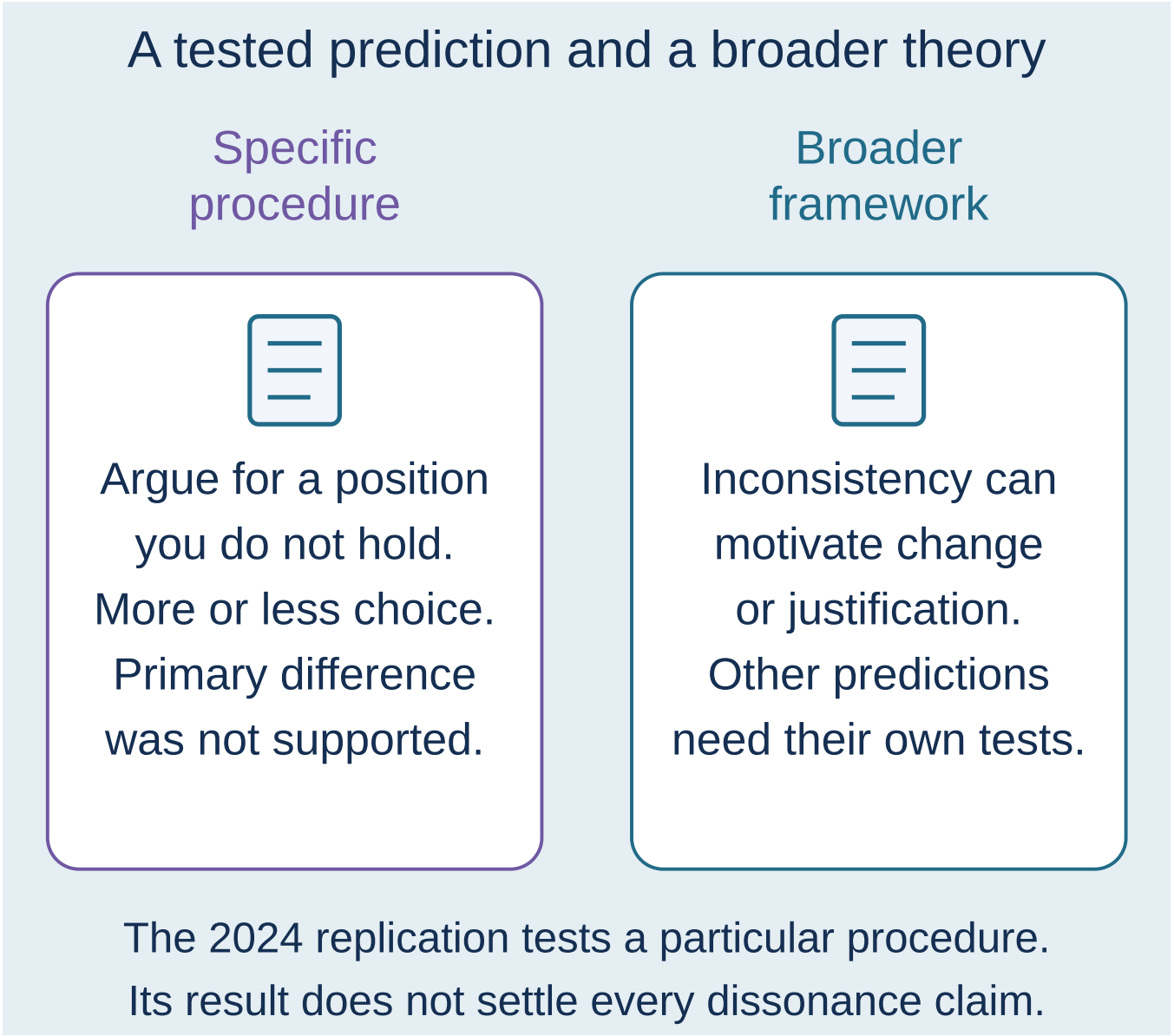
Inconsistency can motivate several different responses.

Sunk cost effect and future consequences



Past spending is unrecoverable; compare future consequences.

A procedure, a prediction, and a theory



The cited replication concerns a particular induced-compliance procedure.

Informational influence and normative influence



The same public agreement can reflect different private reasons.

Compliance and obedience

A request and an authority’s order

Compliance



Leo asks Sam: “Cover my shift?” Sam agrees to the request.

Obedience

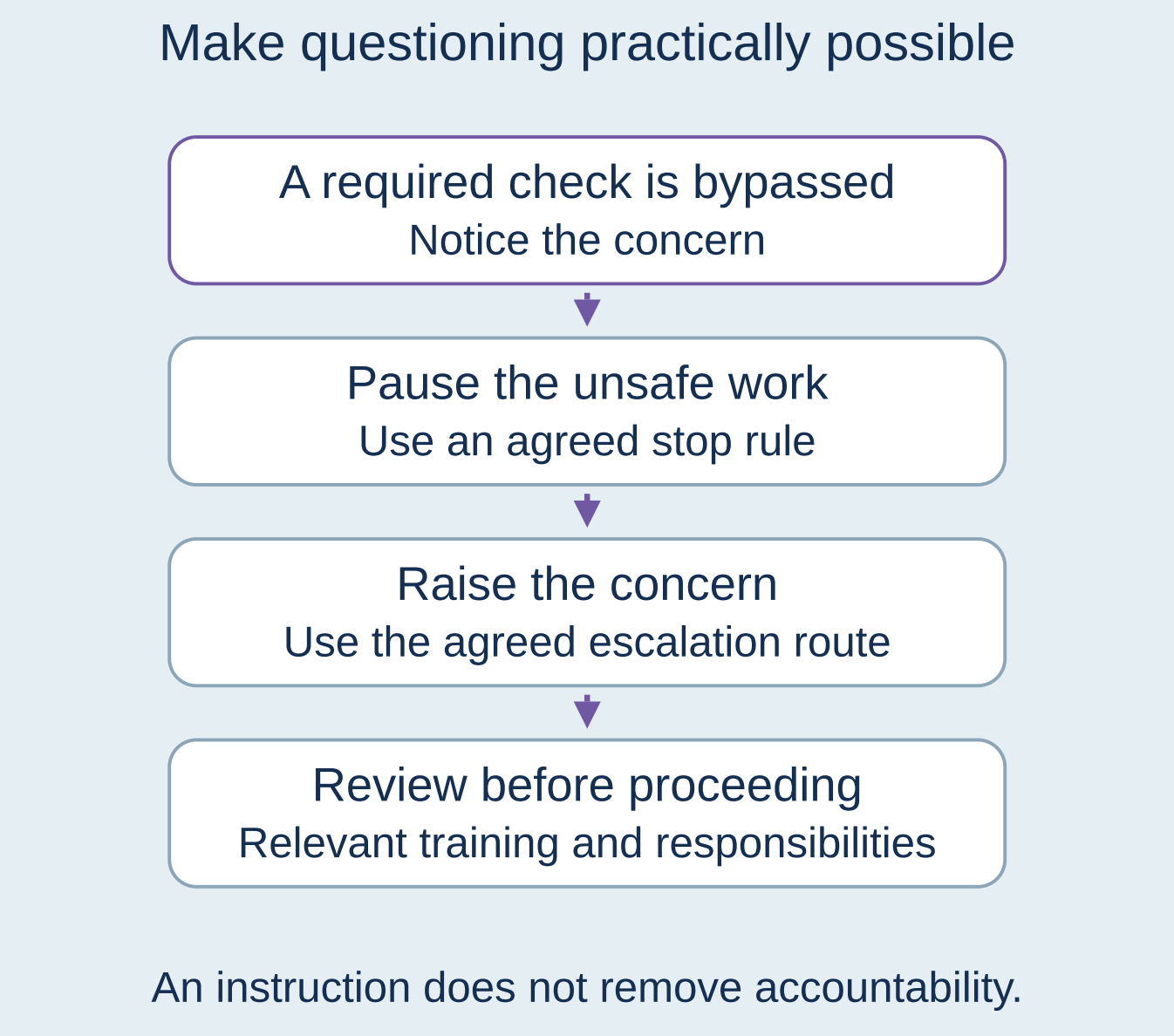


The chair instructs: “Skip the check.” The authority role can add pressure.

An authority’s request can involve both. People can question or resist.

Authority can add pressure; it does not make resistance impossible.

Questioning an unsafe instruction



An agreed route makes a concern actionable.

Classic studies in context

Different tasks, specific pressures

Asch’s task



Compare line lengths after a majority gives incorrect answers. Some people resist.

Milgram’s task

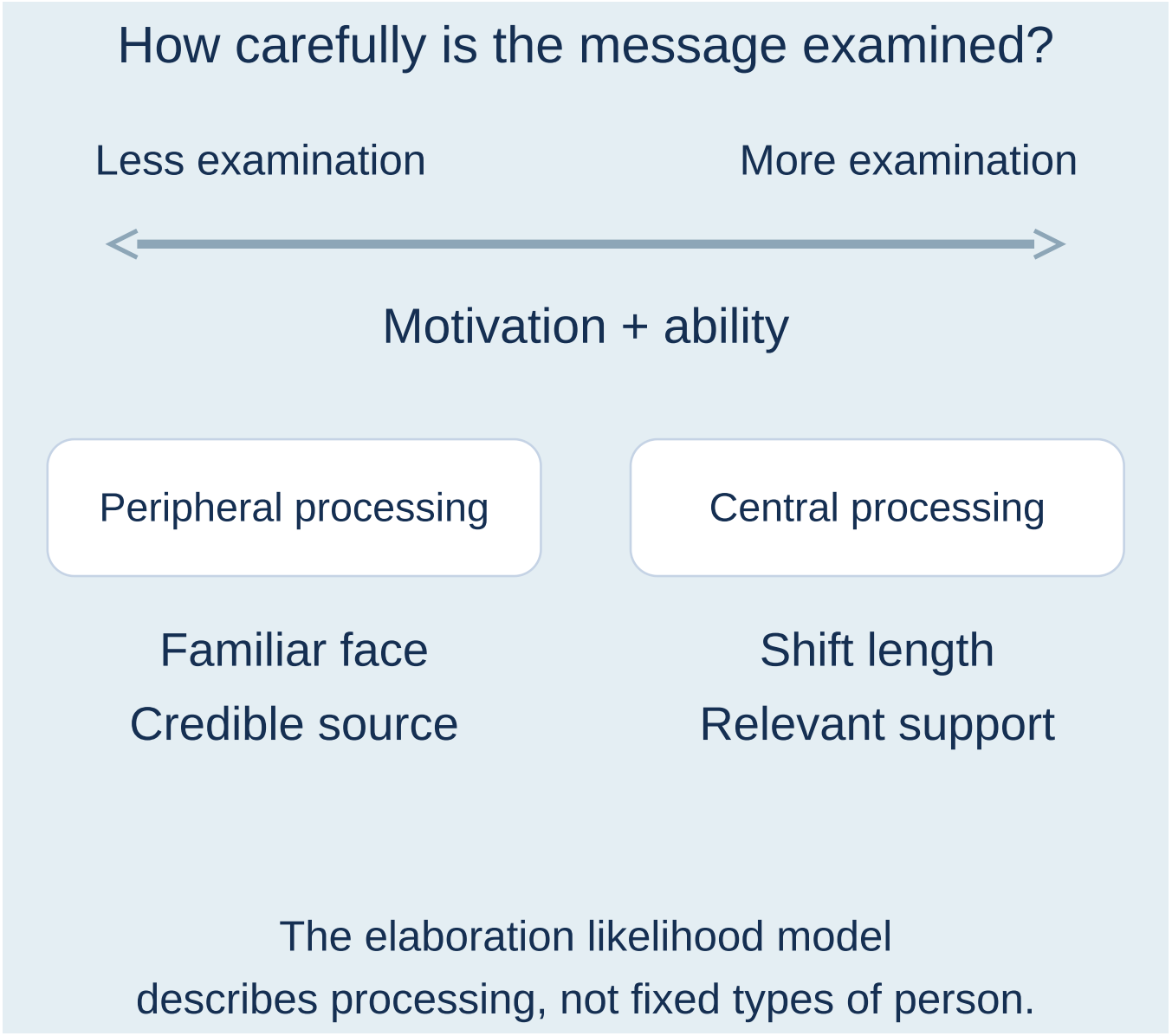


An experimenter urges continuation. Participants believe another person receives shocks.

Methods, ethics, and conditions matter.
These are not universal obedience rates.

Task, setting, ethics, and variation limit generalization.

Central and peripheral processing



The same person can process different messages more or less carefully.

Attitudes and action

An attitude is an evaluation

Possible evaluation



“Volunteering is worthwhile.” Reasons and values shape the judgment.

A different question



Will I sign up? Time, transport, support, and choice also affect action.

A positive attitude does not guarantee action.
Ask what outcome the message needs to support.

An evaluation and an action are related but distinct.

Descriptive and injunctive norms

What happens and what is approved

Descriptive norm



“Many residents volunteer.”
A claim about what people do.

Injunctive norm

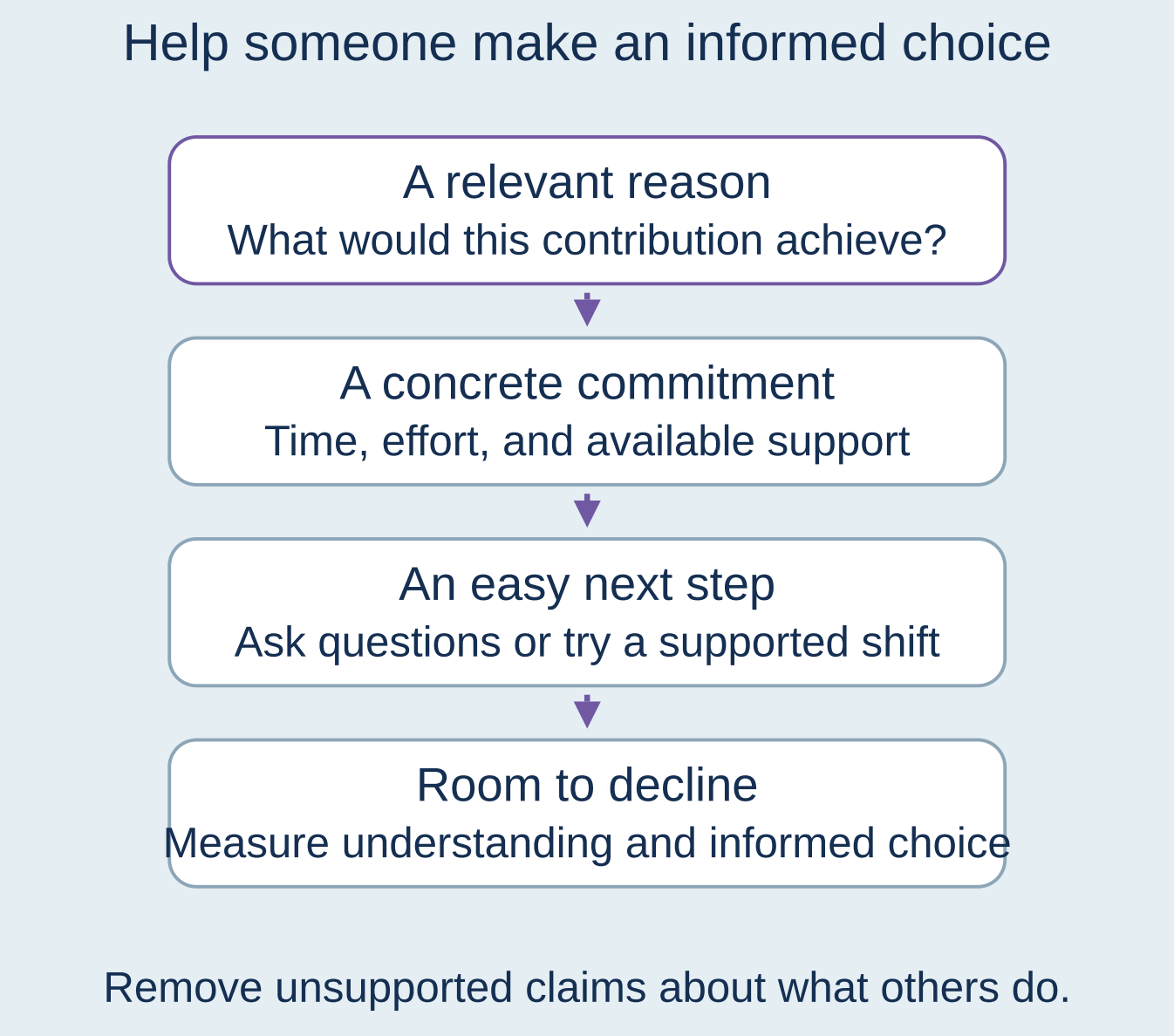


“Our community values volunteering.”
A claim about what people approve.

These are example claims; check their truth.
Highlighting low participation can normalize it.

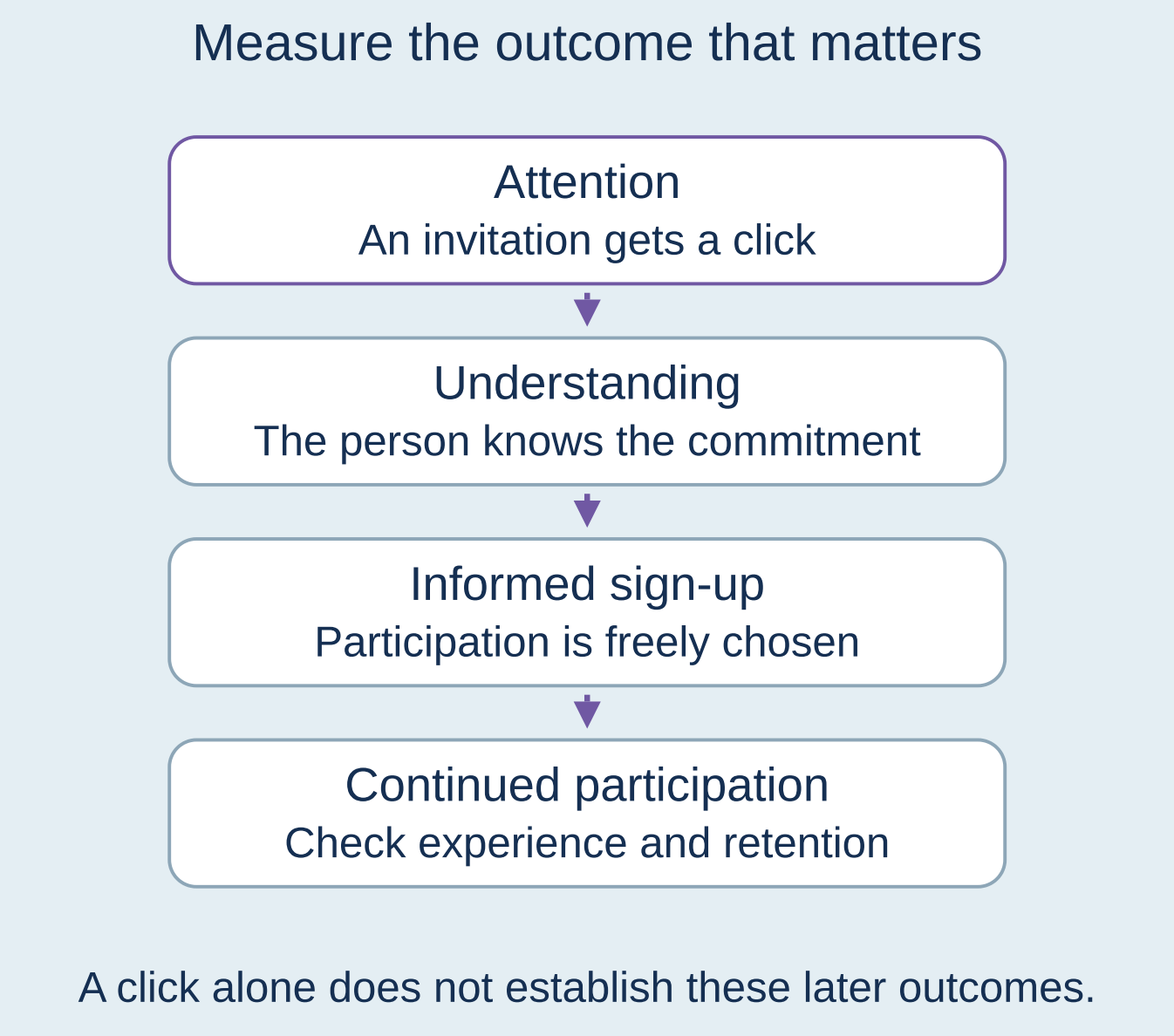
Behavior and approval are different claims; both need evidence.

An honest, usable invitation



Support understanding and preserve meaningful choice.

Attention, understanding, and participation



Measure later outcomes rather than assuming them from clicks.

Social identity and in-group favoritism

Who counts as “our team”?

Repair volunteers



“Give our team first choice of shifts.” Group membership can shape preference.

Welcome volunteers

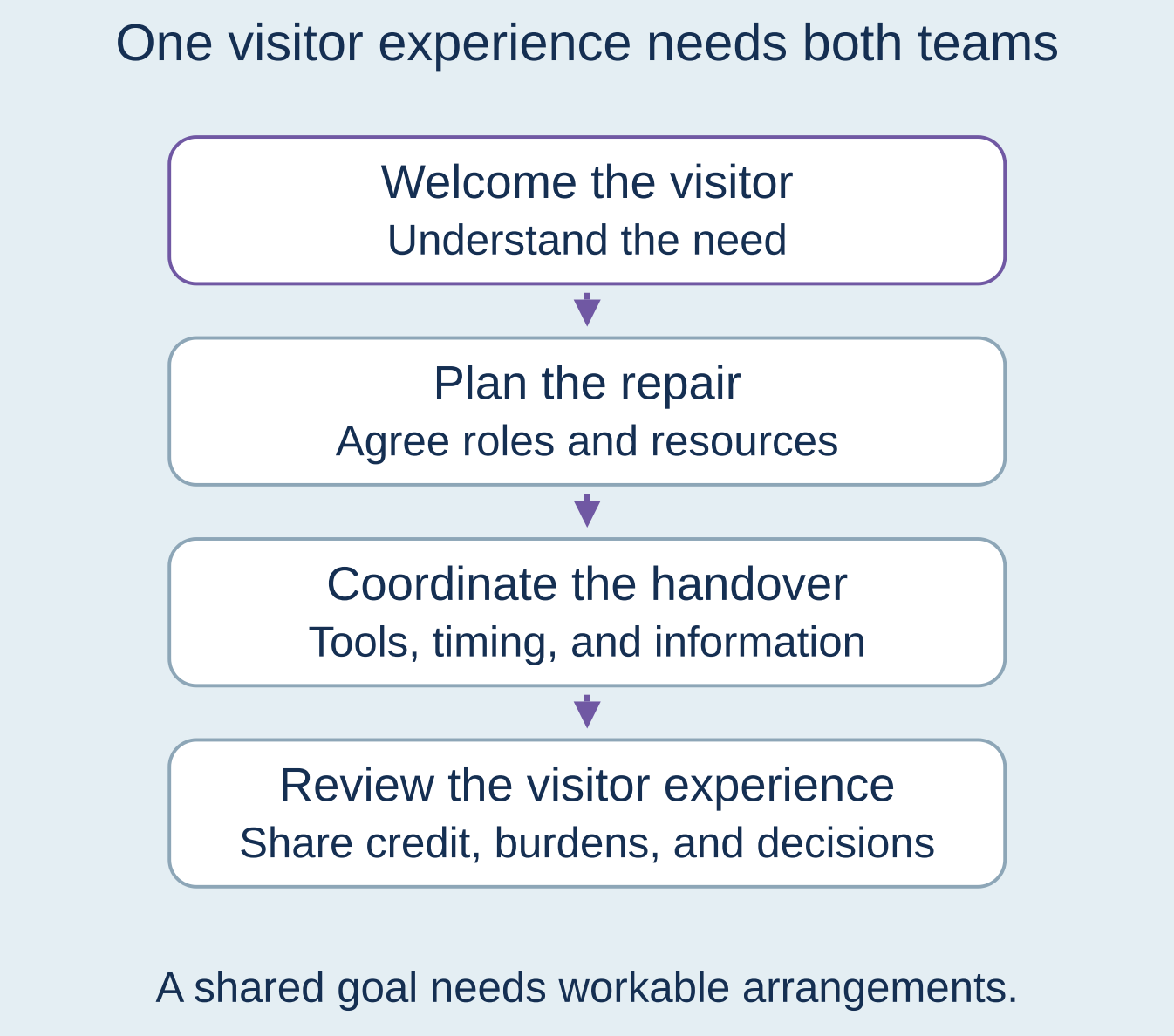


Their contribution can be overlooked. Favoritism can create unequal access without explicit hatred.

Check workload, incentives, and decision power. A shared name alone does not change those.

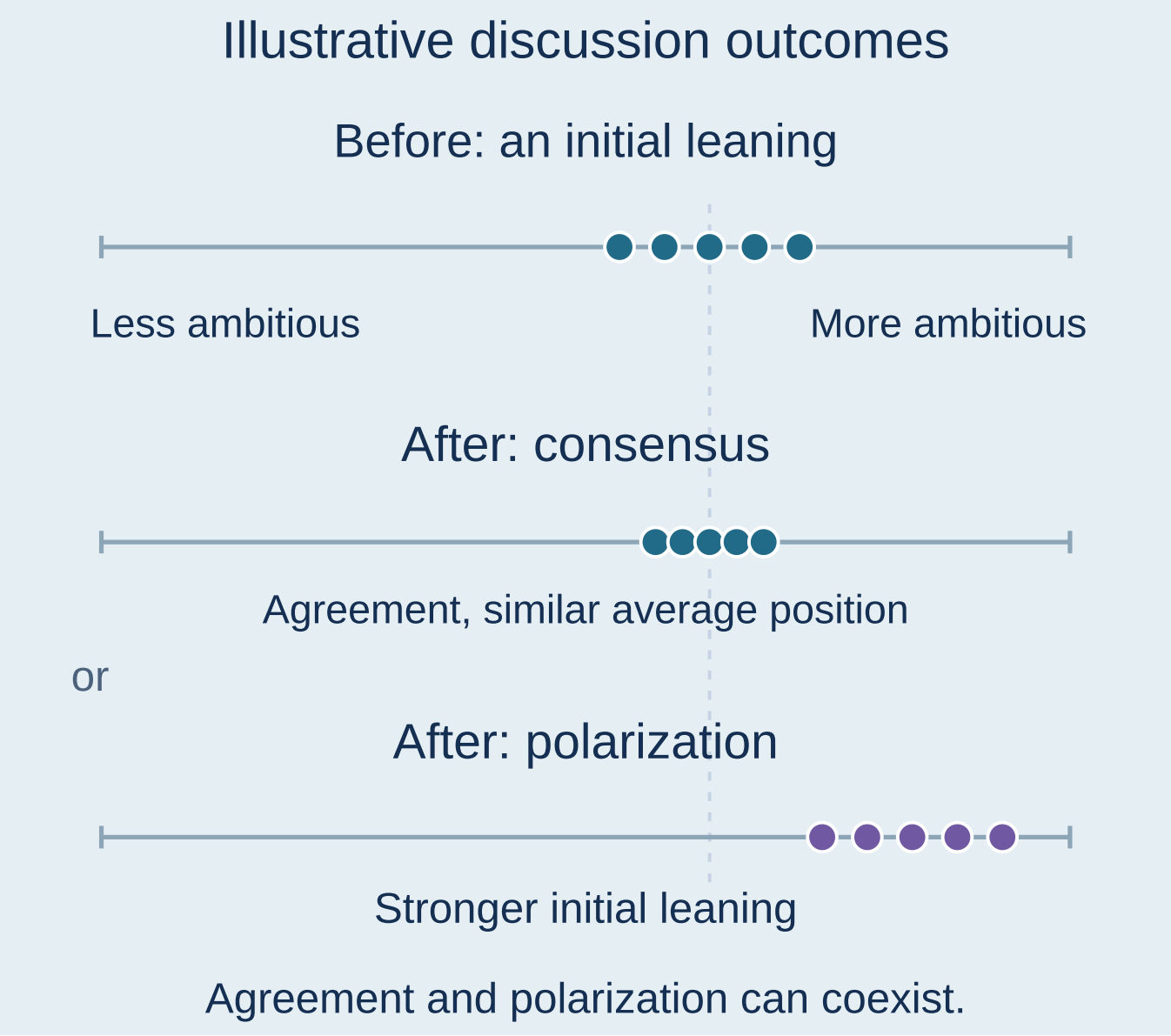
Group preference can produce unequal treatment.

A shared goal and workable arrangements



Shared identity needs coordination, resources, and decision rights.

Group polarization and consensus



Agreement can form with or without a more extreme leaning.

Social loafing and coordination loss

Similar poor output, different processes

Social loafing



Individual effort
falls in pooled work.
“My contribution
will go unnoticed.”
A possible process.

Coordination loss



Effort can be high.
Work is duplicated.
A needed tool
arrives too late.
Tasks do not align.

An unfinished task alone does not identify either.
Check effort, tools, sequencing, and roles.

Different processes require different remedies.

Groupthink and visible decision processes



Ask members about their concerns and check which information reached the discussion.

Stereotypes, prejudice, and discrimination

Three related, distinct concepts

Stereotype: a group belief

“Every newcomer lacks repair skills.”

Prejudice: an attitude

“I dislike newcomers before meeting them.”

Discrimination: unequal treatment

Reject someone for being a newcomer.

These need not form an inevitable sequence.

Belief, attitude, and action are related but distinct.

Rules and unequal access

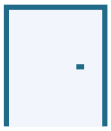


An arrangement can exclude without an openly hostile statement.

Intergroup contact and participation

Sharing a room and sharing participation

Limited participation



Newcomers watch. Established members control the tools and decisions.

Cooperative contact



Work on a shared goal. Share relevant tools and decision-making. Organizers support equal participation.

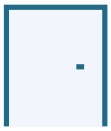
Intergroup contact can help under some conditions. Check actual access and participation.

Cooperation, equal status, shared goals, and support matter.

Procedural changes to access

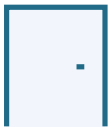
Change the barrier in the process

Existing rule



Apply through existing friends. Bring your own specialist tools.

A proposed change



Open the application. Use relevant criteria. Provide shared tools where feasible. Track participation.

A friendly encounter alone leaves the rule intact. Use follow-up and protect privacy.

Examine who can enter and participate after the change.

Explicit attitudes, implicit associations, and behavior

Different measures answer different questions

Explicit attitude

What someone reports directly

Implicit association

An indirect response pattern in a task

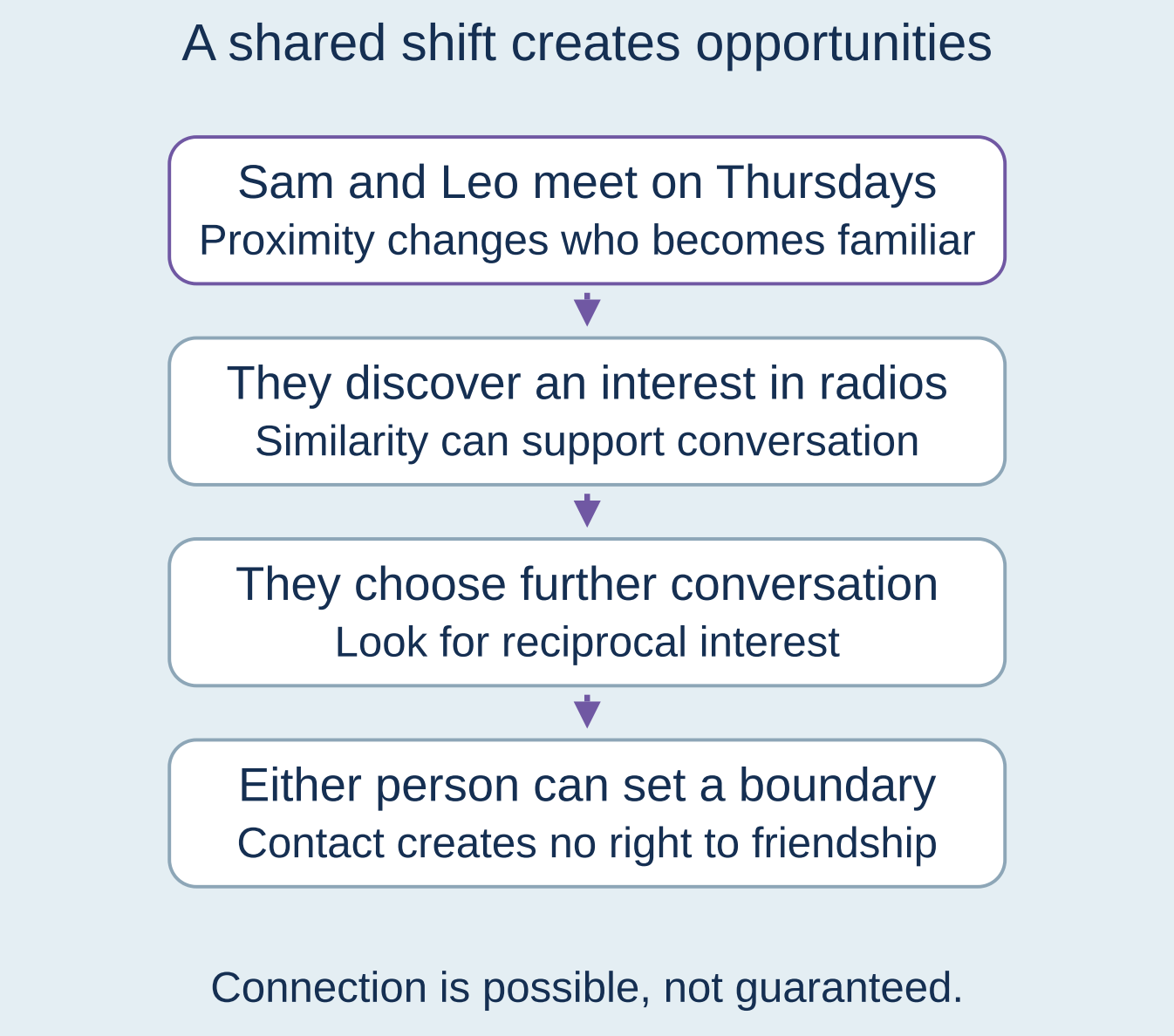
Behavior and access

Who can apply, progress, and participate?

No single score is a complete character diagnosis.

Different measurements do not supply a complete character diagnosis.

Proximity and similarity



Shared settings create opportunities, with mutual willingness.

The mere exposure effect

Repeated encounters can have different effects

Possible familiarity



A face becomes more comfortable to see. Liking may increase.

A different response

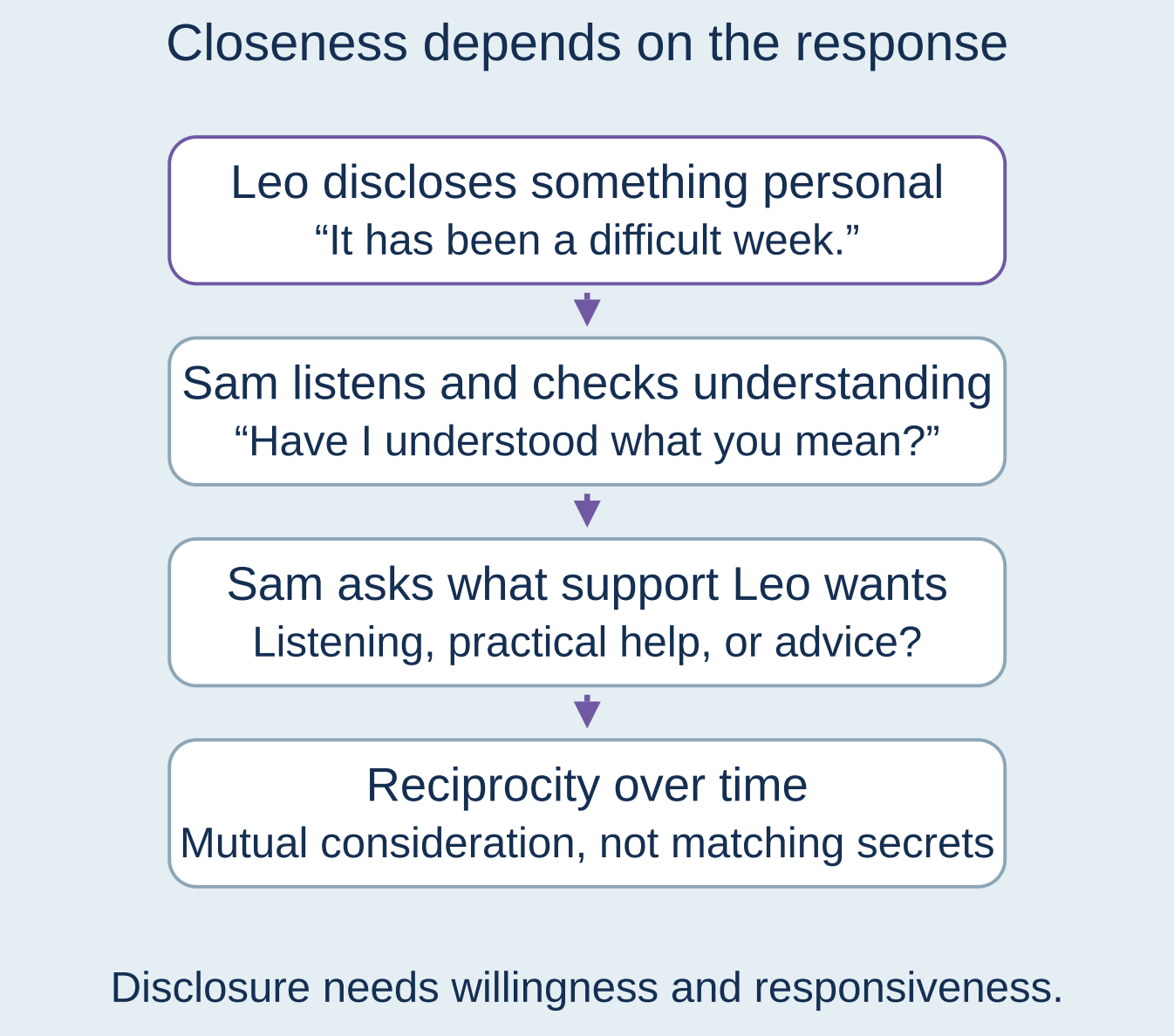


Unwanted contact can intensify annoyance or threat. More is not automatically better.

The mere exposure effect depends on conditions. A stated boundary still matters.

Familiarity has limits and does not override boundaries.

Disclosure, responsiveness, and reciprocity



Connection depends on what each person wants and how the other responds.

Attachment labels and stated boundaries

A declined invitation is useful information

What Sam says



“I need time alone.” An expressed preference for now.

Leo’s response



Accept the refusal. Leave future contact optional. One occasion does not establish an attachment style.

Attachment labels describe studied patterns. They are not diagnoses or permission to persist.

Leo can respect Sam’s preference without inferring an attachment style.

Relationship evidence and its limits

An association and an individual relationship

Study reports



Some partners report greater similarity and satisfaction. Self-reports can have limitations.

Sam and Leo’s situation

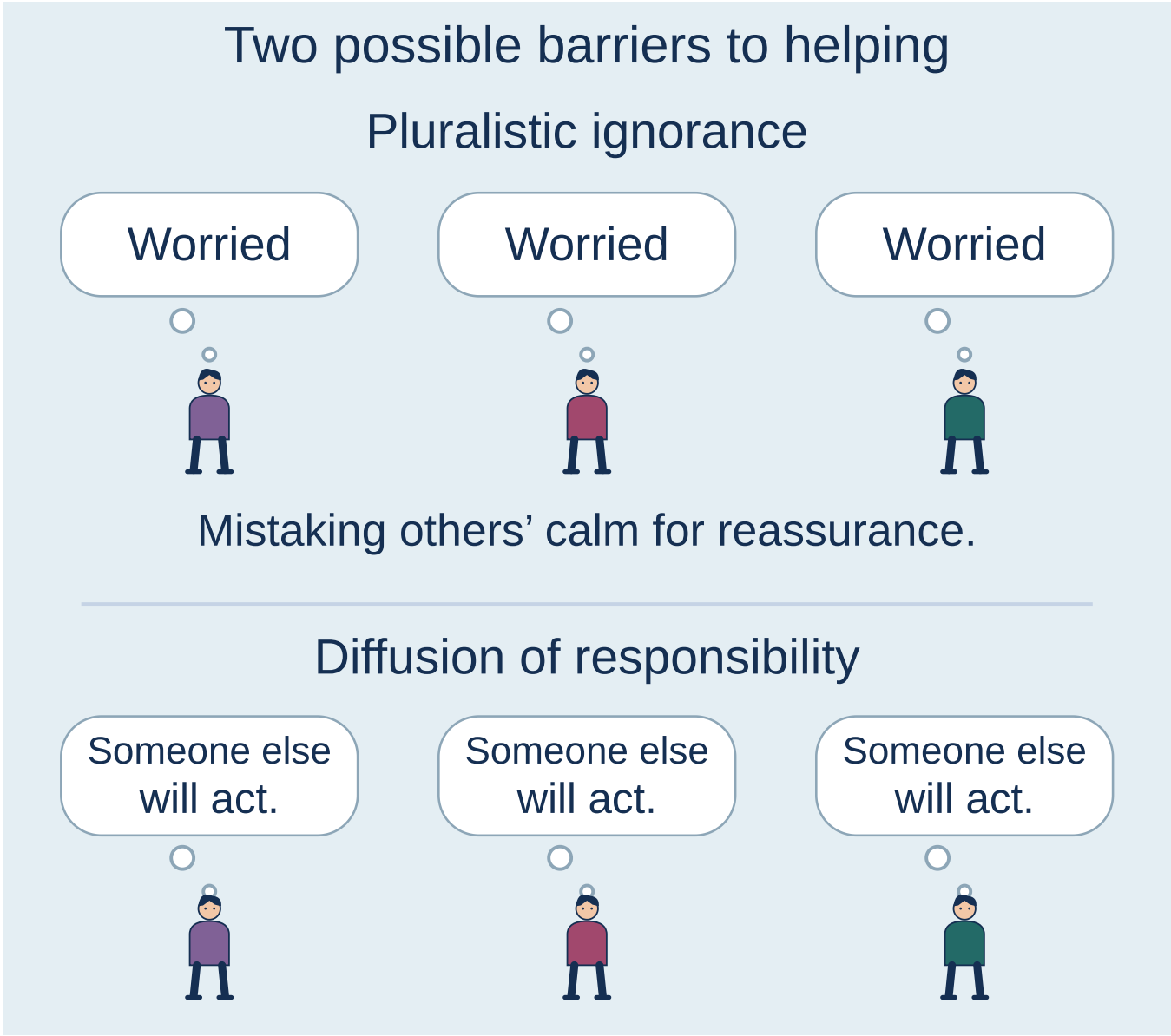


Ask Sam and Leo about their experiences and preferences. A group average cannot choose their goals.

Association alone does not establish an intervention. Ask about the pair’s actual experience.

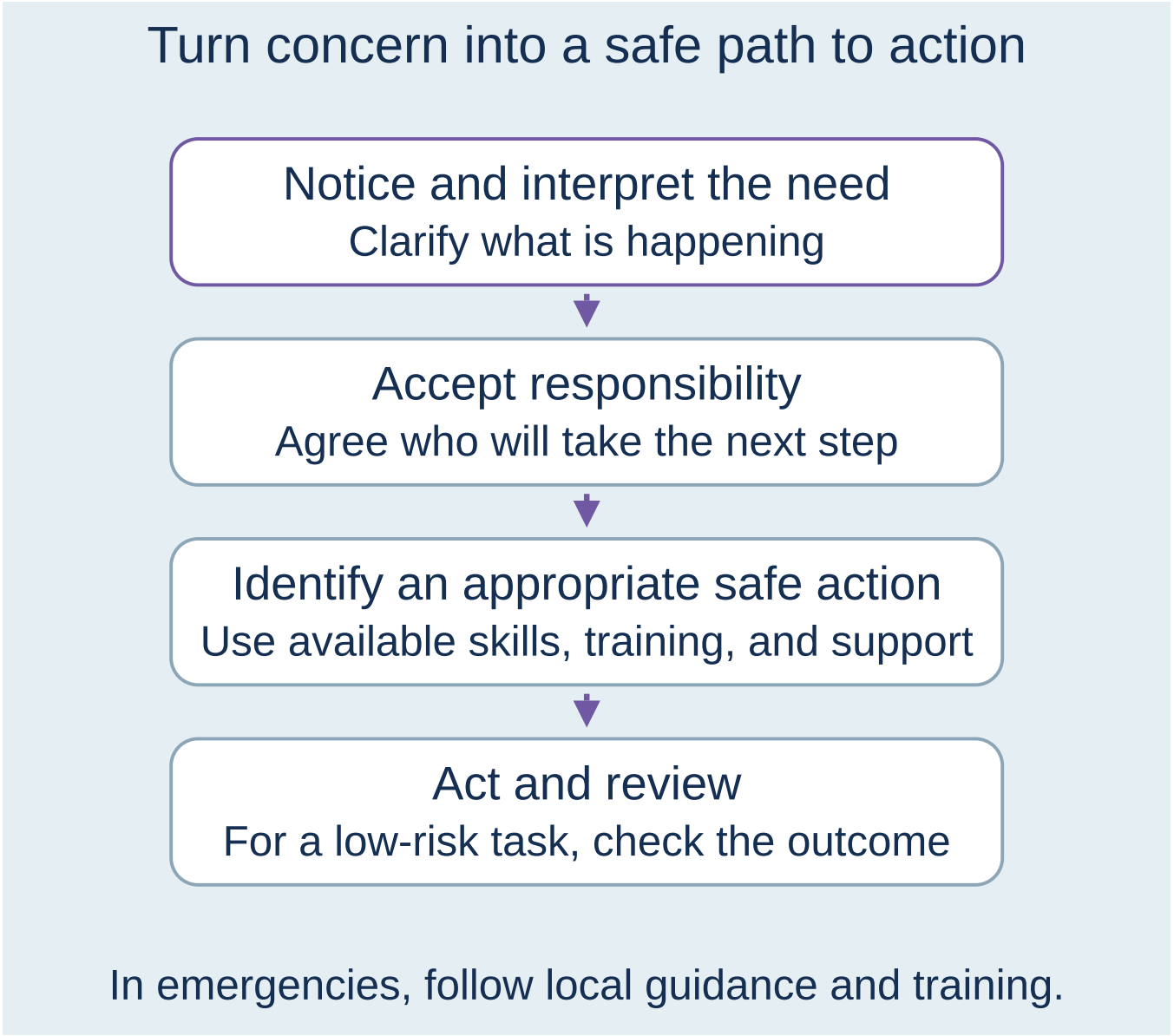
Use research to frame questions, then ask about Sam and Leo’s own experiences and preferences.

Helping and the bystander effect



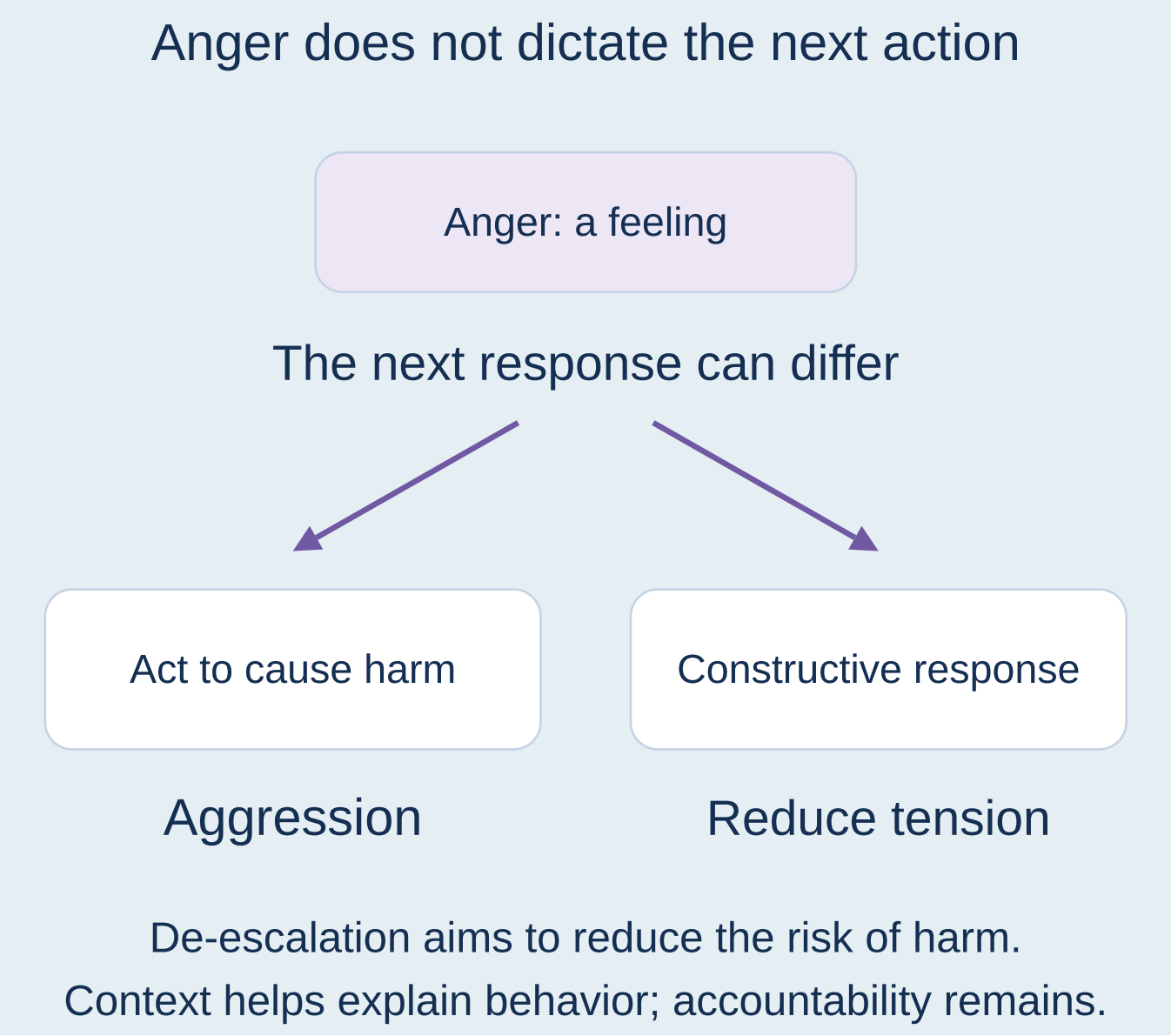
In some settings, others' presence can reduce an individual's likelihood of helping. These are two possible processes; context, skills, and support also matter.

A safe helping process



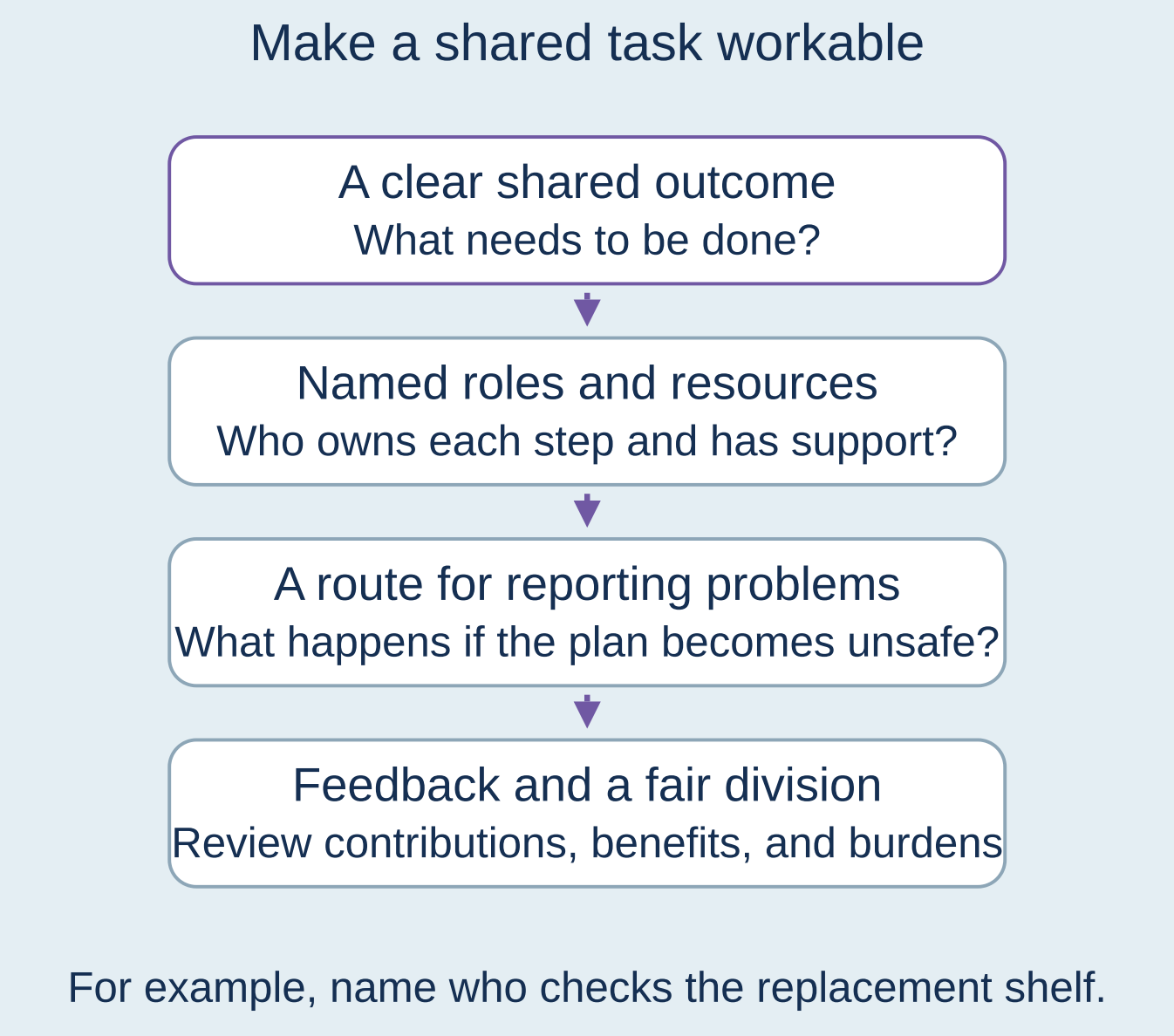
Clear responsibility, skills, and support can make action feasible.

Anger, aggression, and de-escalation



A feeling does not predetermine a harmful action.

Cooperation with roles and feedback



A specific arrangement can turn a shared aim into coordinated work.

Research measures, context, and safe help

A research measure and a real-world decision

Controlled measure



An unpleasant-noise task measures one laboratory response. It is an imperfect proxy for serious violence.

Real-world context



Danger, relationships, training, and support can change what safe help is possible. Crowds can also help.

Interpret the measure within its limits.
A psychology model does not replace training.

Interpret controlled tasks and real incidents with appropriate limits.